

of which are benevolent. Many find themselves drawn into the orbits of powerful shen, especially Kuei-jin. If any group among the Shinma may be compared to the Unseelie changelings, it is the Shu Shen.

☉ The Yellow Lotus

A secret society of the Hsien with a hidden goal, who foment dissatisfaction and even rebellion against the other courts, particularly the Li Shen. However, they also “censure” (a kind way to say “make an example of”) those Hsien they feel are too cavalier about displaying their wani form — their reason for doing so remains as much a mystery as their membership.

☉ Mu Courts — The Greater Demon Courts

Those Hsien who turned their backs to Heaven and surrendered to the Yama Kings when the Fourth Age came joined either the Daityas, who soon turned their backs on the Yama Kings as well, or the Kura Sau, who serve them still. Both work to hasten the oncoming of the Sixth Age, but for their own reasons.

Yin and Yang Legacies

Though several courts, the Shu Shen in particular, might seem to echo the changeling division between Seelie and Unseelie, in truth no such separation exists in Shinma society. Rather, the Hsien are aspected either towards Yin or Yang, though these too do not correspond exactly to Seelie or Unseelie.

The Yin Legacies are Courtier, Hermit, Orchid, Panderer, Saint, Squire, Fatalist, Knave, Outlaw, Riddler, Ringleader, Rogue, and Wretch.

The Yang Legacies are Crafter, Dandy, Paladin, Regent, Sage, Troubadour, Wayfarer, Beast, Fool, Grotesque, Pandora, Peacock, and Savage.

These sides of the character’s personality do not conflict, but complement one another — they are both a part of the character’s soul and persona. When a Hsien’s Yin Chi is higher than her Yang Chi, her Yin Legacy dominates, and vice versa. When a Hsien’s Chi is in balance, she may express either Legacy, switching between them with a moment’s meditation.

Quest: The dominant Legacy’s Quest determines how the Hsien regains Willpower.

Ban: Violating her current Ban troubles the flow of chi through the Hsien’s body, and thus in her environment as well. This is terribly inauspicious and reflects the root causes of the Shinma exile — trouble will certainly follow.

Rank

Though the celestial bureaucracy no longer recognizes the Shinma, the idea of rank still persists among them, as it is ultimately encoded into their very beings. Rank is a rough estimate of the overall power of the Shinma, that being how much Chi she has internalized and made a part of her form. Lower-ranking Hsien generally defer to higher-ranking Hsien, especially within the same court, regardless of whether they actually consider the other to be their superior.

Rank is equal to the sum of the character’s Chi scores. This also determines her maximum Yugen, which is twice her Rank. The Shentao Skill can be used to assess the Rank of other Hsien.

TRAITS

The Shinma use several new or different Abilities. Leadership is now a Talent rather than a Skill, and joins Shentao, which replaces Kenning. Occult replaces Gremayre. Points are distributed among Attributes and Abilities as usual.

Advantages: Luck, Curse, & Backgrounds

Hsien do not have Glamour or Banality — they do not reincarnate to survive in a world devoid of imagination, but because their naked forms are too tempting a target for their enemies.

Hsien have Luck and Curses based on their kith, which give them bonuses and challenges that reflect their natures. A Hsien’s wani form also has unique abilities associated with it, including the ability to use the Mask of Shintai.

Several **Changeling** Backgrounds are expressed differently for the Shinma. Holdings, Remembrance, Retinue, Title, and Treasure have been redefined, and the new Backgrounds Jade Talisman and Pakua are discussed alongside these changes later in this section.

The character receives 5 dots in Backgrounds.

Wu Tan

The sacred magical alchemy of the Hsien is called Wu Tan, and is divided into five elemental arts: Di Tan (earth), Hou Tan (fire), Lin Tan (wood), Tieh Tan (metal), and Shui Tan (water). In addition, a sixth alchemy exists, called Nei Tan, reflecting Daoist internal alchemy.



The Mask of Shintai



Hsien have the ability to assume a terrifying form for but a split second: the form of their past glory. This form terrifies most mortals and can even shock shen into a moment of stunned horror.

System: The Hsien spends as many points of Yugen as she is willing to invest into her Mask of Shintai. Any being that can see her must make a Willpower roll at difficulty 7 (6 for other shen, 5 for other Hsien) and score at least as many successes as the Hsien spent Yugen. Anyone who fails to do so either flees in panic or falls in supplication, begging for mercy. The effect lasts one turn, plus an additional turn for every success by which the target falls short of the total determined by Yugen spent. Should the encounter take place in a dragon nest, each point of Yugen spent requires two successes to match, rather than one.

